M.A English : Syllabus & Format

09/02/26

Master of Arts in English –

2 year postgraduate program focusing on advanced literary studies, linguistics, critical theory and cultural studies.

This is divided into two acedemic years-

1. Previous year – literature papers + History of English language
2. Final year – Advanced Texts, Criticism, Theory, Specialization

Syllabus Structure –

- Each Subject has 5 units.
- Each unit contains 2-4 writers or major texts.
- In exam, one question comes from each writer in unit.
- Internal Choice (OR) is always given.

Previous Year Subjects –

1. Paper-I Poetry – Poetic forms, imagery
2. Paper-II Drama – Conflict, characterization, dialogue and stagecraft

3 Paper - III Prose - Essays and discursive writings

4 Paper - IV Fiction - Novels and Short Stories analyzing Plot, Character, society, and psychology.

5. Paper - V History of English language -

Development from old english to modern english

Exam Structure and Marks -

Maximum Marks - 100, Passing - 36, Time - 3 Hours

Paper I to IV - Poetry, Drama, prose, Fiction

For Fiction - Unit 1-5 Normal Syllabus

Divided into 6 units - units Questions, For unit-6, 5 Q (2 needs to Answered) from any unit

{80-100 words} Unit 1 → Common Passage unit Containing extracts/ stanzas from entire Syllabus.

* Need to solve 5 (10 given) (4 x 5 = 20 Marks)
* Drawn from detailed (D) texts only

{400-450 words} Unit 2 to 6 → For each writer in Syllabus, one question. (16 Marks)

Internal Choice (OR) Provided

We need to attempt one question from each unit.

So, Unit 1 → 5 questions → 20 Marks (4x5)
80 - 100 words

Unit 2 to 6 → 5 questions → 80 Marks (16x5)
400 - 450 words

→ 20 + 80 = 100 Marks
Fiction → Unit 6 → 2 Questions → 10 Marks → 20 Marks
So, for Unit 1, 5 stanzas and for other units 1 question per unit.
For fiction - Unit 1-5 (16 Marks each) + Unit 6 (2x10)
Paper - V - History or English Language

Total units - 5

- Direct Theory questions
- Internal Choice (OR) is given

Each Question → 20 Marks ⇒ 20x5 = 100 Marks

One question from each unit compulsory. Two question for Unit - 5 (May be given as internal
- 500 - 520 words choise in last for units)

In 2 Short answer type questions instead of 1
→ 200 words → 8 Marks (Max 250 words)
for 10 Marks also → 200 words - 250 words

POETRY

09/02/26

Syllabus - D - Detailed, ND - Not Detailed

Imp - Lesson in red are studied in each unit

1. Unit - I

Geoffrey Chaucer - Prologue to the Canterbury Tales D

Edmund Spencer - Faerie Queen - Book - I ND

2. Unit - II

William Shakespeare - Sonnets 18, 26, 54, 60, 116 ND

John Donne - Death be not Proud, Valediction, Forbidden Mourning, Extasie, Canonization ND

John Milton - Paradise Lost, Book - I D

3. Unit - III

John Dryden - Absalom and Achitophel ND

Alexander Pope - The Rape of the Lock D

Thomas Gray - Elegy written in a Country

Churchyard ND

4 Unit - IV

William Wordsworth - Intimations of immortality Recollections of Early childhood, Tintern Abbey D ND

P. B Shelley - Ode to the west wind, Adonais ND

John Keats - Ode to a nightingale, Ode to Autumn D

Samuel Taylor Coleridge - Kubla khan, The Rime of the Ancient Mariner D (All D)

5. Unit - V

Alfred Lord Tennyson - Lotos Eaters, Ulysses ND

Robert Browning - My last Duchess, Prospice, The last Ride Together D (All D)

Matthew Arnold - The Scholar Gipsy, Dover Beach ND

Unit - 1

09/02/26

Geoffrey Chaucer - Prologue to Canterbury Tales

Summary & Context -

Chaucer is telling the story of 30 pilgrims (29 others plus himself) who were making journey to the Shrine of 'Thomas Becket'

* Through the general prologue, he is giving a description of pilgrims in a pleasant and grotesque manner.

At dinner with the pilgrims, the host proposes a plan to the group. He says on the way to Canterbury, each pilgrim must tell two tales and thes two on the return journey.

Chaucer and his Contribution to English language -

Chaucer (1343 - 1400)

"To Chaucer's name eternal trophies raise", For he has been rightly hailed as "the English Homer, the father of English Poetry, the morning star of english Poetry, the earliest of the modern, a perpetual fountain of good sense, the literary titan, and one

who first taught the muse to speak english tongue.

Rightly did Arnold write, "With him is born our real poetry".

J. R Hulbert, Chaucer was most original in characterization. His figures are types as well as individuals.

Prof. Grierson – "Chaucer remains unequalled as the teller of merry tales in verse".

John Dryden – As a metrist and versifier alone he deserves to be called as "the father of english poetry" for he found it brick and left it marble.

Chaucer belongs to Middle English Period / Age of Chau

Themes of Prologue to Canterbury Tales –

1. Social diversity and realism – Realistic Cross section of medieval english society.

2. Ecclesiastical Corruption – Moral decay, hypocrisy and materialism.

3. Appearance Vs. Reality – Pilgrims appears virtuous outward

but are morally flawed beneath the surface

4 Satire and gentle Irony - Humour and mild satire. Ironic descriptions and exaggerated details

Characters - Thirty people represent different professions.

Appearance, Qualities, Representation

Higher Stratum of society and war like element (2C)

- Knight -> Plain, stained Tunic
  Noble, brave, honourable, chivalry
- Knight son -> Short, fashionable gown, (also called Squire)
  Youthful, romantic, courtly
  Love and Chivalry

Learned and liberal profession (4C)

- Man of law -> Sergeant-at-law, Formal robes
  Wise, experienced
  Legal authority
- Doctor (Physician) -> Rich robes of red and blue
  Learned in Medicine and astrology

Deeply Money Minded

→ The Oxford Clerk → Threadbare coat
Poor, devoted to learning
knowledge over wealth

→ Poet himself → Simple dress
Modest, observant and polite
Objective Narrator

Highers, Commercial Community (2C)

→ Merchant → Forked beard, motley dress
Shrewd, Money-minded
Trade and profit

→ Shipman → Rough Clothes
Bold, lawless sailor
Piracy

Traders and Manufacturers (1C)

→ Wife of Bath → Scarlet stockings, large hat
Dominant, experienced
Female sovereignty

Agriculture (3C)

→ Ploughman → Plain Clothes
Honest, hardworking
True labour

→ Miller → Short coat, red beard
Drunken, crude

Brutal Strength

→ Franklin → White beard, rich dress
Hospitable, pleasure-loving
Epicurean life

Service Class (4 C)

Upper Servants of Society (2 C)

→ Manciple → Modest attire
Clever despite low status
practical Intelligence

→ Reeve → Long, thin build
Bitter, controlling
Authority through fear

Lower Servants of Society (2 C)

→ Yeoman → Green Coat and hood
Skilled woodsman
Archery

→ Cook → Stained apron
Skilled but unhygienic
Corruption beneath Skill

Ecclesiastical Order (Associated with Christian Church) (5 C)

→ Monk → Rich fur-lined robes
pleasure loving, worldly
Anti-ascetic

→ Prioress (Madame Eglantine) →
→ Neat Cloak, Coral beads
→ Affected Manners, Sentimental
→ French (Stratford-atte-Bowe)
→ (Not Paris)

↳ Parson → Simple dress
Truly virtuous priest
Ideal christianity

↳ Friar the Pardoner → Flashy Clothes, long hair
Greedy, Manipulative
Fake relics

↳ Summoner → Leprous face, loud dress
Corrupt church officer
Ecclesiastical abuse

C → Characters
10/02/26
Important Quotes – Stanzas, Excerpts and quotes

Opening Spring lines –

"When the Aprill with his shoures soote
The droghte of March hath perced to the roote"

Shows Spring, renewal, birth (rebirth) and the urge to travel.
Sets the pilgrimage frame of the poem.

Knight's Description (Ideal Society) –

"He was a verray, parfit gentil knight."

- Defines Ideal, Medieval knight
- Represents Chivalry, honour, truth, nobility
- Chaucer benchmark moral for other characters.

About the poet - Geoffrey Chaucer, Era,

Admirers and Titles -

Age & Era - Middle English period, also called Age of Chaucer in his honour

14th Century (1350 - 1400)

Admirers / Critics and Title Given -

1. Matthew Arnold - Called Chaucer "the poet's poet"

2. John Dryden - "The father of english poetry"

3. William Hazlitt - praised Chaucer's human sympathy and realism

4. Legouis - said Chaucer had "free, fresh and genial humour".

Sec 1 12/26

John Milton - Paradise Lost, Book - I

Summary & Context -

Paradise lost is a poetic rewriting of the book of Genesis. It tells the story of fall of Satan and his compatriots, the creation of man, and most significantly, of man's act of disobedience and its consequences: paradise was lost for us.

Book - 1 of paradise lost begins with a prologue in which milton performs the traditional epic task of invoking the muse and stating its purpose. He invokes the classic muse, Urania, but also refers to her as the "Heav'nly Muse", implying the christian nature of his work.

About the Poet - Era, Age, Admirers, Critics, Contribution and titles -

John Milton (1608 - 1674)

Age - 17th Century, Puritan Age / Late Renaissance

Era - Period extending from 1625 to 1660 is generally described as "The Age of Milton".

This period marks the end of what is known as Renaissance

Admirers, Critics and titles Given -

1. John Dryden - Milton cuts us all out and the ancients too

2. Samuel Johnson - Admired milton moral grandeur (but criticised his style).

3. William Blake - Said Milton was "of Devil party without knowing it" (about Satan)

4. T.S. Eliot - Criticised Milton's influence on English Poetry (Negative but famous).

Contributions - Milton, the greatest product of Puritanism -

In his work, the moral and religious influences of puritanism in English literature are combined with the generous culture of Renaissance.

His Poetry was called grand style. Arnold called Milton supreme master of grand

Style

Themes of Paradise Lost -

1. Disobedience and fall of man - Central theme is Adam and Eve's disobedience to God, which leads to the fall and lost of paradise.

2. Free will and predestination - Milton emphasizes that humans and angels are given free will; the fall happens by choice, not by Fate.

3. Good Vs Evil - Presents a moral conflict between God and Satan, showing how evil rises from pride and rebellion.

Epic Similes - Simile is a figure of speech that directly compares two distinct, often unrelated things.

Milton use of similes is both remarkable and distinct.

1. Satan compared to Leviathan - Emphasizing his gigantic and terrifying size.

2. Fallen angels compared to autumn leaves -

Showing their vast number and defeat

3 Satan shield compared to moon - Moon seen through a telescope, highlighting epic scale and grandeur

4. Satan compared to tower or mountain - Reinforcing his heroic yet terrifying appearance.

Characters - Qualities, Appearance, Representation

Satan
- Proud, Ambitious, eloquent, rebellious
- Gigantic, Majestic yet dark; later reduced to a serpent
- Evil born from pride, misuse of free will

God
- Omnipotent, just, merciful, all-knowing
- Pure light and glory; never described fully
- Absolute divine authority, justice and order

Beelzebub
- Clever, persuasive, strategic
- Fallen Angel, less majestic than Satan